RESEARCH PARTICIPANTS' VIEWS:
ETHICAL GUIDELINES FOR ARCHIVING AND SHARING STORIES OF MIGRATION FOR FUTURE REUSE

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WHY?

- Research funders in the UK have funded much social science research into the global migration crisis from 2015 onwards
- Research explores intimate, difficult aspects of migrant lives and creates a historically significant record of the testimonies of refugees
- Despite data management plans showing intentions to archive the data, ethical challenges meant very little of the data ended up preserved in an archive

ETHICAL COMPLEXITIES

- vulnerable participants
- sensitive topic
- personal stories told difficult/impossible to anonymise
- different cultural background ~ different understanding of ethics and consent
- researchers uncertain whether data reuse for different purposes is ethical
- researchers are also nervous about responsibility for future reuse of their data
- valuable stories
- unique resources for future research and policy
- participants may want their voices heard

CAPTURING TESTIMONY OF THE CONTEMPORARY MIGRANT CRISIS

- Seminar UK Data Service, November 2019
  - Anca Vlad, Maureen Haaker, Louise Corti, Veerle Van den Eynden, Comms team
- Bring together stakeholders to discuss the complexities and opportunities of sharing, archiving and reusing sensitive qualitative data
- 15 speakers / 24 participants: presentations and discussion groups
- Funded by the UKRI Economic and Social Research Council through the Global Challenges Research Fund (GCRF)

SPEAKERS

- Migration data in use: reusing data for policy and research
  - Ed Packard, University of Suffolk – (De)fragmenting the refugee archive: researching the Basque children of 1937
  - Norah Karrouche, Vrije Universiteit Amsterdam and Erasmus Universiteit Rotterdam – Reusing community oral histories to explore the history of postcolonial migration to Rotterdam
- Sharing migration data: challenges & possibilities
  - Darena Hristozova, New Europe Centre for Regional Studies, Plovdiv University, Bulgaria – GEMM project: The lived experiences of migration
  - Katharine Jones, MEDMIG project, Coventry University
  - Ann Singleton, Mediterranean Missing project, Bristol University
  - Giorgios Tsimouris, Pantheion University, Greece – Transitory Lives: An Anthropological Research of the Migration Crisis in the Mediterranean
- Laura Hammond, SOAS University of London, GCRF Challenge Lead for Conflict and Displacement
- Research participants' perspectives on risks and opportunities for archiving and reuse of migration stories
  - Elio Tozzi, Borderline Sicily; Dora Papadopoulou, Greek Asylum Service; Eleonore Kofman, Middlesex University and Alessio D'Angelo, University of Nottingham – EVI-MED project partnership
  - Maryssa Jallad, American University of Beirut and Relief Centre, UCL – Citizen Social Scientists as stewards of community knowledge in Hamda, Beirut
  - Nina Moraitou-Politsi, Refugee Council UK – Advocacy work with refugees
  - Giulia Sbaffi, Archive of Migrant Memories (Archivio delle memorie migranti), Rome
  - Shakir Syed, research participant's perspective

HIGHLIGHTS

HISTORIANS REUSING PAST MIGRATION STORIES

- Basque children of 1937
  - official voices and records well preserved: correspondence, meeting minutes, documents, committee reports
  - child refugee voices absent: first personal stories available for use:2012-2017
  - distorts the reality that can now be retraced
- Tools for reuse of qualitative data in secure controlled environment, respecting ownership and confidentiality
  - CLARIAH Media Suite
- Revisiting past research is important to analyse how history happened

RESEARCH PARTICIPANTS' PERSPECTIVES

- Participants want their contribution to have effect
  - maybe nor for themselves
  - for migrants in general, future generations, policy
- Researchers
  - are NOT neutral
  - responsibility to pursue impact and make findings approachable
- Participants as partners, not researched subjects
  - co-create community knowledge
  - co-produce testimonies, documentaries
  - role of gatekeepers (grassroots organisations)
- Voices need to be heard

Archivio delle memorie migranti (2019) Oltre i muri - Beyond the walls

POLICY & ADVOCACY RE-USE

- Case studies on migration and refugees needed for policy and decisions
- Often through charities working with refugees and migrants
- Drain on resources of small NGOs
- Sharing archived data early (secure setting) can facilitate rapid use in policy

RECOMMENDATIONS

ARCHIVING AND FUTURE USE

- Longterm embargo reduces risk to participants
  - time makes reuse easier
- Future use likely different from current research
  - historians may be interested in vulnerability of migrants
  - what seems sensitive and confidential, may not be that for historians
  - migration stories for empowerment/identity construction (nation building)
  - oral histories used in teaching
- Vignettes (short stories about hypothetical people) or using pseudonyms can contribute towards anonymization

METHODOLOGY

- Too much emphasis on interviewing people in research ?
  - migrants and refugees also interviewed by officials for asylum application process
  - interviewed by multiple research projects
  - interviewed multiple times by social services or government agencies
  - difficult to understand different purpose of interviews
  - 'rehearsed' interviews to researchers, to align with asylum stories
- Alternative methods of generating data / capturing experiences
  - participant-centred research methods
  - co-created and co-owned data are easier to share, e.g. participatory documentaries, citizen science
- Allow time and space to engage and communicate with research participants about ownership and future of collected information

ETHICS

- Standard ethics procedures and consent forms limiting in complex circumstances / different cultures
  - no meaningful information to inform participants about potential risks
  - no match to reality on the ground
  - informed consent may be meaningless in some cultures or situations
- Researchers to be more explicit in explaining how data may (not) be used in future
- Highlight value of collected stories beyond the research, e.g. value towards community building / community engagement
- Researchers can never be neutral in research: participants may always hope to benefit from participating in research
- Sharing research data more widely can facilitate this to some degree, opening up more opportunities for change